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Salamatt Husain / Gulf News

UAE RINGS IN NEW YEAR WITH SPECTACULAR CELEBRATIONS

Crowds gather to watch New Year's Eve fireworks at Global Village in Dubai. The UAE welcomed 2026 in spectacular fashion, lighting up the night sky with dazzling fireworks that brought together residents and visitors in a shared celebration of hope and new beginnings. Festivities stretched across all seven emirates, ensuring that communities nationwide could be part of the moment. From coastal displays to neighbourhood gatherings, the message was clear: In the UAE, every new beginning is celebrated in extraordinary fashion.

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DXB braces for peak New Year travel period

4-HOUR AIRPORT RULE, HOME CHECK-IN AMID JAN 2-5 SURGE

DUBAI
BY NIVETHA DAYANAND
Assistant Business Editor

Dubai is heading into one of its most congested travel windows of the year, with airlines and airport operators warning passengers to prepare for heavy crowds and longer journey times in the days after New Year.

Emirates has advised customers to expect significant pressure at Dubai International Airport between tomorrow and January 5, a period that combines post-holiday returns, school restarts and overlapping travel patterns across multiple regions. The airline is urging passengers to arrive at least four hours before departure, citing likely delays on surrounding roads, crowded car parks and longer queues inside terminals.

Pressure on DXB

Dubai Airports has already flagged the scale of the movement. Nearly two million passengers are expected to pass through DXB over an eight-day stretch which began on December 27, with daily traffic averaging up to 245,000 travellers. Tomorrow is forecast to be the busiest day, with over 257,000 passengers. The rush comes after a strong year for tourism. Dubai welcomed 17.55 million overnight visitors between January and November 2025, a 5 per cent increase from the same period a year earlier, according to data from the Department of Economy and Tourism.

DXB GETS BUSIER



257,000
passengers expected at DXB tomorrow, the busiest day

Millions expected

Nearly 2m flyers are expected to pass through DXB over an 8-day period.

1 Average daily traffic: During the 8-day stretch which began on Dec 27, daily traffic will be averaging up to 245,000 travellers.

2 Strong year for tourism: Dubai welcomed 17.55m overnight visitors from Jan to Nov 2025, a 5% increase from the same period in 2024.

Airline pushes alternatives

To manage the pressure, Emirates is steering travellers toward off-airport check-in options. Its City Check-In and Travel Store at ICD Brookfield Place in DIFC allows passengers to check in and drop luggage up to 24 hours before departure, with free parking and extended operating hours through mid-January. A similar round-the-clock service is available at the Ajman Central Bus Terminal.

For those willing to pay for convenience, Emirates' Home Check-In service in Dubai and Sharjah offers door-to-door check-in and baggage handling, allowing passengers to arrive at the airport with hand luggage only. The service is complimentary for First Class customers and Platinum Skywards members.

Metro, the fastest route

With expected road congestion, the Dubai Metro is the most reliable option. The Red Line connects directly to Terminal 3, offering an alternative to taxis during peak periods. Airlines are also encouraging travellers to complete seat selection and document checks online before arriving, reducing time spent at counters.

Tourism momentum extends into 2026

Analysts say the January surge reflects a broader shift in Dubai's tourism profile. Beyond leisure travel, business events, conferences and medical tourism are driving year-round demand. Emirates NBD pointed to health care-related travel as a growing contributor, supported by longer stays and higher spending.

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